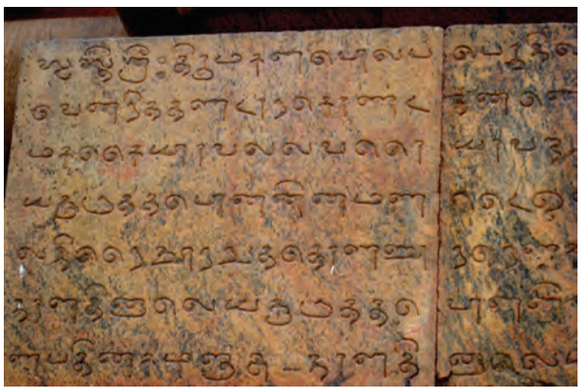
We examine the details of political, economic and socio-cultural developments with the aid of sources.

Primary Sources: Inscriptions, monuments and coins, and the information available in them.

Secondary Sources: Literary works, chronicles, travelogues, biographies and autobiographies.

Inscriptions

Inscriptions are writings engraved on solid surfaces such as rocks, stones, temple walls and metals. The king's royal decrees, dedications and donations, monuments raised in commemoration of victories in wars, those built in memory of deceased warriors, contain rich information about the concerned era. Copper-plate grants, which were treated as legal documents, have significant source value. The Islamic-Persian practices and the relatively high cost of copper plates made palm leaf and paper cheaper alternatives from 13th century onwards.



Rock Inscription

Several copper-plate grants issued during the later Chola period (10th to 13th century) record gifts to individual priests or teachers who were Hindu, Buddhist, or Jaina, or to persons of eminence. Both the giver and the receiver are very elaborately described. By contrast, most stone inscriptions differ in their content.



Copper plate Inscription

In stone inscriptions, the beneficence of a donor is recorded. The major focus is upon the giver. Tiruvalangadu plates of Rajendra Chola I and the Anbil plates of Sundara Chola are notable examples. Uttiramerur inscriptions in Kanchipuram district provide details of the way in which the village administration was conducted.

Various types of lands gifted by the Chola kings are known from the inscriptions and copper plates. They are:

Vellanvagai	land of non-brahmin proprietors
Brahmadeya	land gifted to Brahmins
Shalabhoga	land for the maintenance of a school
Devadana	land gifted to temples
Pallichchandam	land donated to Jaina institutions

Monuments

Temples, palaces, mosques, tombs, forts, minars and minarets are called by the collective name monuments.

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Dilwara Temple Mt. Abu

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